Epiphany

By Heidi Decker

(Woman, 20-30. Articulates well, but speaks as if everything is one continuous thought and sentence. Not ditzy by any means, only genuinely perplexed. She has been up for hours, mulling something over. She speaks aloud to try to make some sense of it all.)

INTRODUCTION

A usually sudden manifestation or perception of the essential nature or meaning of something. An intuitive grasp of reality through a simple and/or striking event. An Epiphany. We've all had those moments when the "light bulb goes on," the synapses in our brains click and we realize the meaning of some random thought or event. Some people call it an "AHA" moment.

But what if your "AHA" moment makes no rational sense? What if your"AHA" makes you begin to doubt your sanity. This is the story of a crab, a woman, and . . . . an Epiphany by Heidi Decker.

All right, maybe I'm just losin' it. It's not unheard of, these days, for someone to just lose it for no apparent reason. Maybe that's it. Either that or I've had some deeply symbolic, spiritual experience and I just didn't get it. I don't know.

All I know is that now, I can't get it out of my head. It's just there, right behind my eyes, and it won't leave me alone.

Don't get me wrong, I'm not obsessed or anything. It's just that I feel like the whole thing is supposed to . . . I don't know . . . tell me something. I know how really dumb that sounds. I just wonder if this is one of those experiences that you read about. . . things that don't hardly ever happen, and when you try to explain it, out loud, it sounds really dumb, but in some weird way it can change your life. . . sorta. See, last night I was leaving work, it was about ten o'clock at night, and I was hungry but I didn't have very much money. I decided to go to the grocery store

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because it's open 'til midnight and they have a deli section where they have fresh sandwiches made every day and after nine o'clock at night they mark them half price 'cause they have to get rid of them 'cause they can't sell them the next day. . . because they're advertised to be made fresh every day. So, you can get a really big sandwich for a dollar.

Then I began walking across the back part of the store to the dairy section to get some milk. I was walking along, trying to decide whether I wanted skim or two percent, when something in the seafood section caught my eye.

You know how a lot of grocery stores have a big tank with lobsters in it? And there's usually about a dozen all piled in there, with rubber bands wrapped around their claws so they can't snap at anyone, or defend themselves or anything. . . Well, last night there weren't any lobsters. One tank was empty, and the other had seven or eight crabs in it. Big ones. Kind of like soft-shell but not exactly. . . maybe they were snow crabs. . . you know, with those huge front claws that you see people in restaurants pounding on with a hammer.

Apparently these guys were a specialty item running for a few days. What caught my eye was this: all those crabs were huddled over in one corner, looking like they were trying to keep warm or play king of the mountain or something. . . all but one. One of them was way far away from the others. He was sitting right at the edge of the tank, pressed up against the glass, and, I swear to God, watching what was going on in the store. Like a little kid with his hands pressed against the glass watching some guy toss pizza crust.

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Well, there's no one around but me, so I was the only thing moving. . . and. . . you know how they have those little eyes on top of their heads?

Every time I moved, they would follow me. Back and forth, up and down. Now that's not so strange. I'm sure had he been in the ocean he would have been watching whatever happened to be moving.

I stepped up close to the glass and I guess it kind of startled him because his eyes disappeared into his head for a few seconds, but I stood there and slowly his eyes came back out. I bent down a little bit and put my hand up to the glass. It was really cold outside and I still had my gloves on. I'm crouched down next to a lobster tank with my hand up against the glass watching this crab watch me, when I heard someone pushing a shopping cart pass by me.

The noise made me remember where I was and I stood up quickly, and as I did, the crab's eyes ducked back down into his head. I stood there for a few seconds, waiting, but they didn't come back out again.

I noticed that my hands were getting sweaty so I took off my gloves and as I did, I happened to look at my watch and saw that it was getting late. I started to walk away when. . . I swear. . . I heard a little. . . tapping. . . noise.

I looked back, and that crab was tapping the glass with one of his claws. He was lifting one of his front claws a little and tapping steadily on the glass. I'd never seen anything like it. Well, who has? So I crouched down again to get a closer look.

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He just kept. . . tapping. . . until finally I put my fingers against the glass, right in the spot where he was tapping. He stopped. He just left his claw there on the glass.

I tapped my fingers, twice, against the glass. He tapped back. Twice! I swear. I tapped once. He tapped once. I don't even know why I think it was a he, I just do. And then. . . and then, I put my other hand against the glass. And waited. And slowly, he lifted his other claw, and put it against the glass, opposite of where my hand was.

So I'm in the middle of this grocery store, crouched down nose to nose with the daily under-the-sea special and. . . and for a second. . . I swear to you, for a second. . . . I. . . felt. . . something.

I don't know what. I know it sounds ridiculous but he had his claws against my hands and my eyes were level with his, with just half an inch of glass between us and for a second I felt. . . something. . . right in the middle of my chest. Not like heartburn or anything, just, sort of, I don't know. . . warm. I guess. I could feel it on my skin, but inside too. . . kind of like a . . . glow. Just for a second.
Then he brought his claws back down. He backed away and turned away a little, then stopped, and kind of looked at me . . . then turned himself around and crawled to the back of the tank. I just crouched there and watched him, half expecting him to turn and wave, with a sunset shimmering behind him.

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By now my knees were killing me so I stood up, kinda shaky. I left the sandwich I was going to buy there, on the floor, and walked out of the store. Out in the parking lot it was freezing cold, but I could still feel that. . . whatever it was . . . it was the strangest feeling. I got in my car and went home. I was in kind of a daze, I guess.

And so now, I can't get it out of my head. I know it sounds weird but nothing like this has ever happened to me, and what if. . . well, what if, at some point in your life, everyone has some sort of experience, something unusual like this, and it's supposed to mean something, to tell you something. . . and I just don't know what.

I mean, really, what? Don't eat seafood? What was I supposed to do, buy him? Where would I have kept him? (Sigh) I mean, some people hear voices, some people have visions. . . but me, I . . . I have a spiritual experience with a ... crab. What the hell does that mean?!?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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